

UPSC PHILOSOPHY OPTIONAL

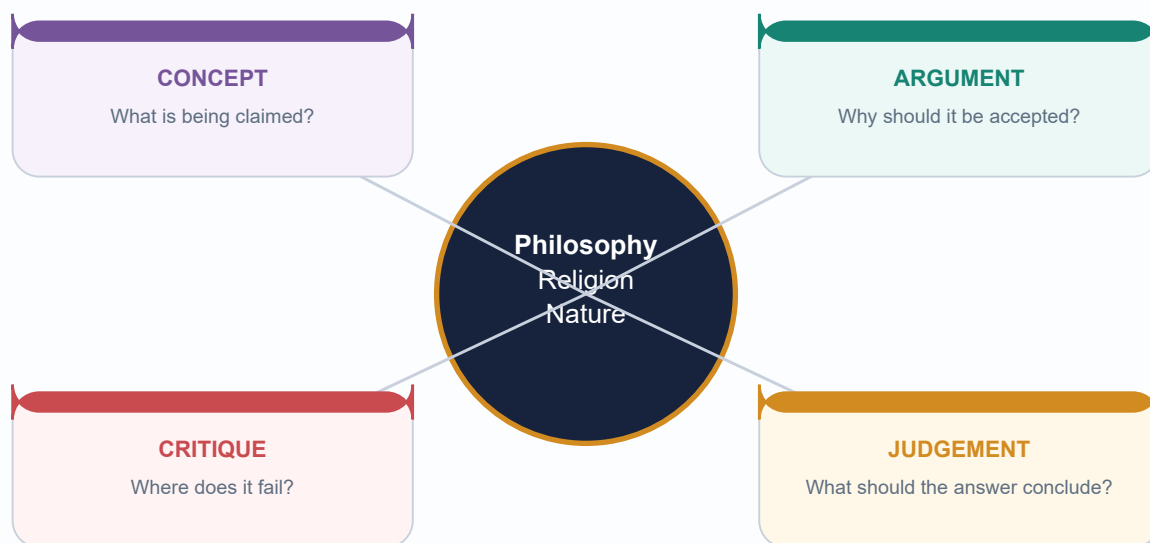
Philosophy of Religion: Nature of Religious Language

UPSC Philosophy Optional | Paper II | Philosophy of Religion

Syllabus: Nature of Religious Language: Analogical and Symbolic; Cognitivist and Non-cognitive.

Direct local-PDF base: John Hick, local PDF pp. 93-119; Oxford Handbook, Religious Language (PDF pp. 232-260) and Wittgensteinianism (PDF pp. 458-483); Philosophy of Religion A-Z entries on analogy, symbol, verification and language-games; C. D. Sharma on Advaitic negation. Cross-check: verified Paper-II knowledge note and verbatim 2022-2025 PYQ bank. The local sources provide secondary exposition of Aquinas and Tillich; exact quotations are used only where independently standard and short.

Content-rich visual edition: arguments, matrices, Indian perspectives, PYQs and answer frameworks



Facts from official sources | Inferences clearly marked | No fabricated data

HIGH UPSC RELEVANCE

HIGH

Language Matrix: How Can Finite Speech Refer to the Infinite?

Paper II
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

Religious language has two axes: how predicates apply to transcendent reality and whether religious utterances state facts. Analogy, symbol and negation address meaning; cognitivism and non-cognitivism address truth-aptness and function.

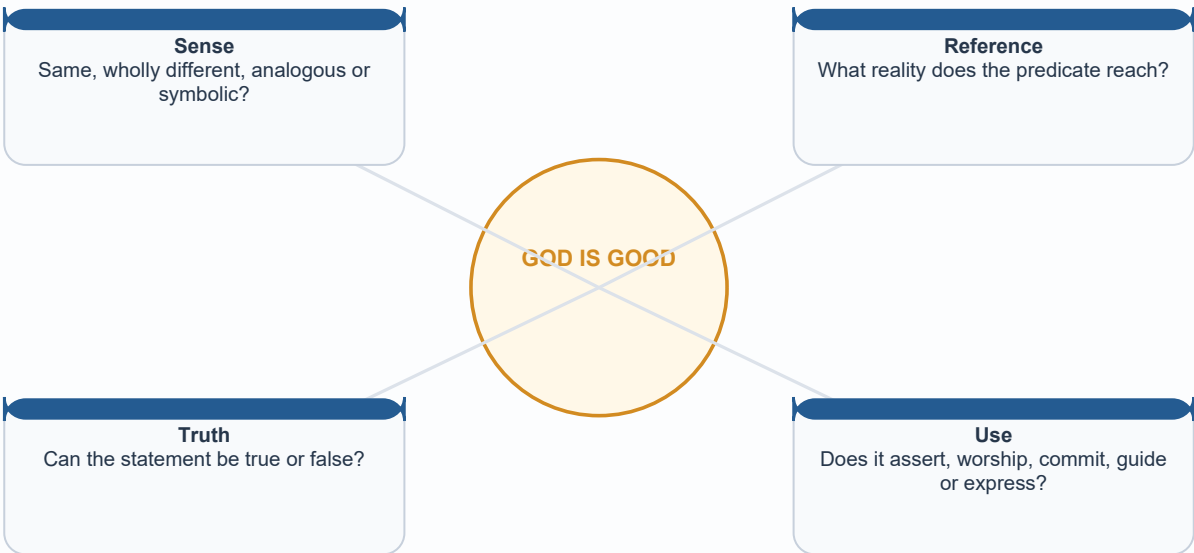
Direct local-PDF base: John Hick, local PDF pp. 93-119; Oxford Handbook, Religious Language (PDF pp. 232-260) and Wittgensteinianism (PDF pp. 458-483); Philosophy of Religion A-Z entries on analogy, symbol, verification and language-games; C. D. Sharma on Advaitic negation. Cross-check: verified Paper-II knowledge note and verbatim 2022-2025 PYQ bank. The local sources provide secondary exposition of Aquinas and Tillich; exact quotations are used only where independently standard and short.

TWO-AXIS MAP

MEANINGFUL GOD-TALK WITHOUT LITERAL ANTHROPOMORPHISM

Analogy Terms apply truly but proportionately, neither univocally nor equivocally.	Symbol Symbols participate in and open access to the reality indicated.
Negation Via negativa and neti neti deny finite limitations.	Cognitivism Religious assertions are truth-apt claims about reality.
Non-Cognitivism Utterances express commitment, attitude, blik or form of life.	Verification Meaning is challenged by empirical verification or falsification tests.

FOUR QUESTIONS ABOUT 'GOD IS GOOD'



STATIC THEORY

- **Univocal risk:** using predicates in exactly the creaturely sense makes God finite and anthropomorphic.
- **Equivocal risk:** wholly different meanings destroy intelligibility and inference.
- **Analogical middle:** predicates have related but proportionate meanings grounded in creature-Creator relation.
- **Non-cognitive turn:** some theories preserve practical force by denying or suspending factual assertion.

MEMORY HOOK

HOW: Analogy/Symbol/Negation. **WHETHER:** Cognitive/Non-cognitive.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Analogy of attribution relates creaturely goodness to God as source.
2. Analogy of proportionality applies a perfection according to different modes of being.
3. Tillich distinguishes symbols from signs because symbols participate in what they indicate.
4. Braithwaite treats religious assertion as commitment to a moral way of life supported by stories.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Analogical means vague similarity.

CORRECT: It is a disciplined middle between identical and unrelated meaning.

WRONG: Symbolic means false or merely decorative.

CORRECT: For Tillich, symbols disclose and participate in reality.

SYLLABUS AND CONCEPT LINKS

Core Concept	Linked Debate	Answer Use
Divine predicates	Notions of God	Language determines how attributes are understood.
Verification	Logical positivism	Connect Ayer, Flew, Hare and Mitchell debates.
Ineffability	Religious experience	Experience exceeding words motivates symbol and negation.
Anirvacaniyata	Advaita	Use neti neti and levels of discourse carefully.

MAINS ANGLE

Religious language is best treated as analogical or symbolic yet still cognitively answerable, while non-cognitive theories capture its lived force.

STUDY LINK

Nature of Religious Language: Analogical and Symbolic; Cognitivist and Non-cognitive.

HIGH

Core Concepts, Vocabulary and Internal Logic

Paper II
Philosophy

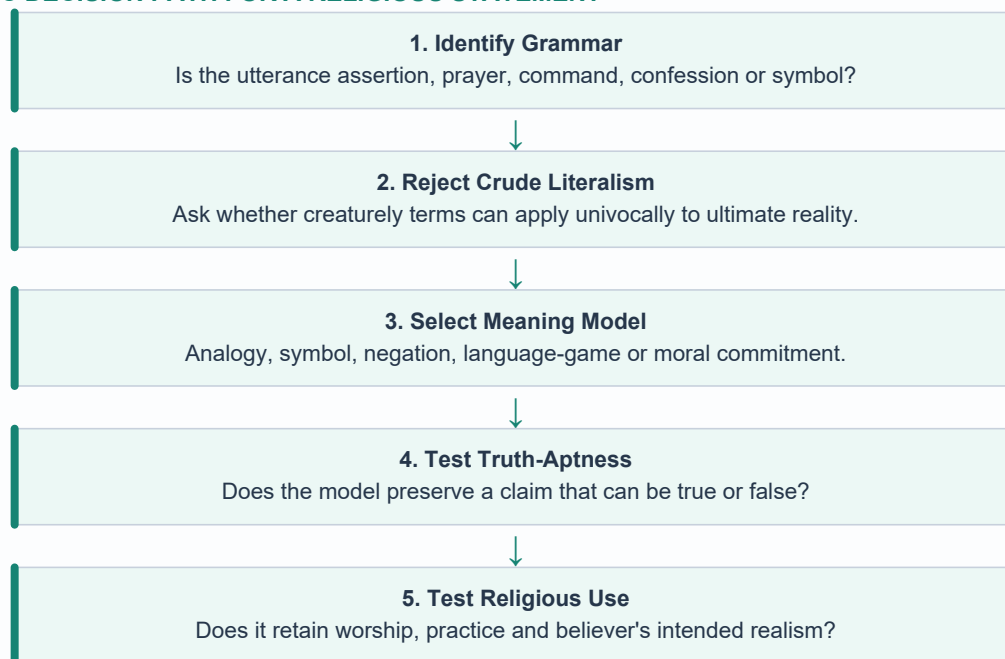
INTRO & ORIGIN

Do not collapse the semantic question of meaning into the epistemic question of proof.

Definitions are followed by the argument's premises and conclusion so that the doctrine can be reconstructed rather than merely named.

KEY DATA

Term / Position	Precise Meaning	Exam Use
Univocal	A term has exactly the same sense in creaturely and divine use.	Anthropomorphism risk.
Equivocal	A term has wholly unrelated senses.	Meaninglessness risk.
Analogy of attribution	Creaturely perfection points to God as source or cause.	Aquinas.
Analogy of proportionality	A predicate applies according to each being's mode.	Aquinas.
Symbol	A sign-like form that participates in and opens a level of reality.	Tillich.
Cognitivism	Religious utterances assert truth-apt propositions.	Realist reading.
Non-cognitivism	Religious utterances primarily express commitment, orientation or practice.	Braithwaite/Wittgenstein.

SEMANTIC DECISION PATH FOR A RELIGIOUS STATEMENT**STATIC THEORY**

- **Aquinas:** analogy protects both similarity and greater dissimilarity between Creator and creatures.
- **Tillich:** God is not one being among beings but Being-itself; literalisation of symbols becomes idolatry.
- **Braithwaite:** religious stories support a moral intention, but critics say this omits belief that God really exists.
- **Wittgensteinianism:** meaning depends on use within a form of life; critics charge insulation and fideism.

MEMORY HOOK

GRAMMAR -> MODEL -> TRUTH -> USE.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Wittgensteinian approaches locate meaning within language-games and forms of life.
2. Logical positivism treats unverifiable metaphysical assertions as cognitively meaningless.
3. Advaitic anirvacaniyata and neti neti mark the limits of determinate predication.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Non-cognitive means emotionally unimportant.

CORRECT: It can emphasise moral commitment, practice and life-orientation.

WRONG: Ineffability forbids every statement.

CORRECT: Negative, analogical and performative language may still point or guide.

MAINS ANGLE

A theory fails if it saves religious use by erasing the believer's intended reference to reality.

STUDY LINK

Use this card for definition, exposition and premise-conclusion reconstruction.

HIGH**Classical, Contemporary and Indian Perspectives**Paper II
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

The language-theory matrix should show meaning, truth status, religious function and weakness together.

The comparison matrix keeps similarities and differences on the same axes; Indian positions are included where they alter the structure of the debate.

KEY DATA

Theory	Meaning / Truth Status	Principal Weakness
Aquinas' analogy	Cognitive; proportionate true predication.	How is the proportion known?
Tillich's symbol	Disclosive and participatory; not crudely literal.	Reference may become indeterminate.
Via negativa	Meaning through denial of finite limitation.	Risk of empty or silent theology.
Verificationism	Unverifiable God-talk lacks cognitive meaning.	Criterion may be self-defeating and too restrictive.
Braithwaite	Moral intention and way of life.	Reduces realist belief to ethics.
Language-game	Meaning in religious practice and form of life.	Fideism and weak external criticism.
Advaita	Indicative, negative and level-relative discourse.	Ultimate indescribability complicates doctrine.

STATIC THEORY

- **Cognitivist realism:** 'God exists' intends to describe reality even if evidence is disputed.
- **Non-cognitive value:** captures expressive, conative and performative dimensions neglected by fact-only analysis.
- **Contemporary synthesis:** religious utterances may have multiple speech acts while retaining a cognitive core.

MEMORY HOOK

MEANING / TRUTH / USE / RISK: four columns mentally for every theory.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Analogy and symbol answer 'how meaningful', not automatically 'how verified'.
2. A language-game account need not say every religious sentence is non-cognitive.
3. Advaita distinguishes empirical teaching language from ultimate non-dual truth.

UPSC TRAPS

- WRONG:** Calling Tillich straightforward non-cognitivist.
- CORRECT:** His symbols disclose Being-itself and are not mere emotive expressions.
- WRONG:** Calling Wittgenstein a logical positivist.
- CORRECT:** Meaning-as-use rejects the verificationist demand for one function.

CROSS-PAPER ENRICHMENT

Paper-II Theme	Paper-I / Indian Link	Value Added
Analogy	Aquinas / proofs	Predicates in conclusions require semantic clarification.
Language-games	Later Wittgenstein	Use form of life without making religion immune to critique.
Neti neti	Vedanta	Connect negation with anirvacaniyata.

MAINS ANGLE

A plural speech-act account can recognise assertion, worship and commitment without reducing all religious language to one function.

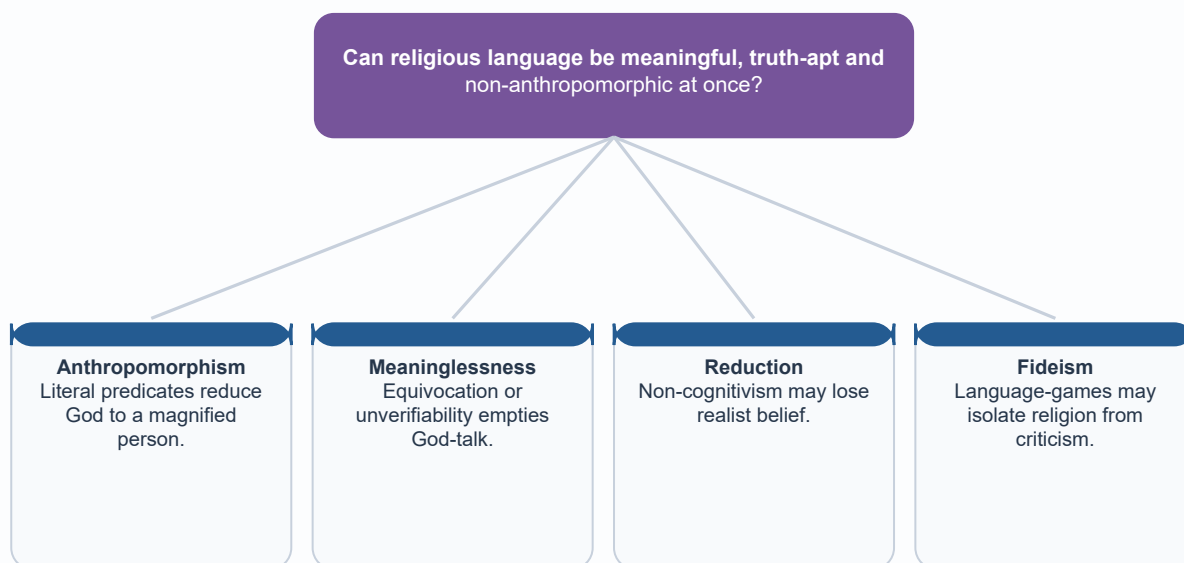
STUDY LINK

Deploy one Western and one Indian comparison only when it sharpens the question.

HIGH**Objections, Replies and Qualified Assessment**Paper II
Philosophy**INTRO & ORIGIN**

The debate turns on anthropomorphism, verification, reference, fideism and reduction of religious belief to ethics.

A strong answer presents the strongest objection in its best form, then tests the reply without treating either side as automatically decisive.

MEANING AND TRUTH PRESSURE POINTS

KEY DATA

Objection	Reply / Qualification	Final Assessment
Analogy is too indeterminate	Causal attribution and proportionality provide disciplined similarity.	Meaning is preserved, though exact proportion remains obscure.
Symbols do not assert truth	Symbols disclose and participate rather than merely decorate.	Tillich still needs a stable account of reference.
Unverifiable statements are meaningless	Verification can be eschatological or meaning can exceed empirical test.	Truth conditions remain difficult to specify.
Braithwaite saves religion by secularising it	Moral intention captures genuine practical force.	It does not capture believers' ontological commitment.
Language-games are immune to evidence	Internal grammar explains use; practices can still face moral and conceptual critique.	External truth assessment remains contested.
Anirvacaniyata makes teaching self-refuting	Provisional language removes ignorance and is later sublated.	The pedagogical use must be distinguished from final description.

STATIC THEORY

- **Falsification debate:** believers must state what, if anything, would count against their claims.
- **Eschatological verification:** some claims may be verified at the end of the religious journey without present falsifiability.
- **Indian two-level reply:** language is valid at the empirical level even if ultimate reality exceeds subject-predicate form.

MEMORY HOOK

SAVE MEANING without losing TRUTH or PRACTICE.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. A sentence can have cognitive and performative functions simultaneously.
2. The verification principle itself is not straightforwardly empirically verifiable.
3. Indescribability should be expressed as limits on exhaustive predication, not total absence of knowledge.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Saying analogy proves God's attributes.

CORRECT: It explains predicate meaning, not existence or evidence.

WRONG: Saying non-cognitive language is false.

CORRECT: If not truth-apt, it is evaluated by function rather than truth or falsity.

MAINS ANGLE

Analogical-symbolic cognitivism best preserves reference, while non-cognitive theories remain indispensable for explaining religious use.

STUDY LINK

Write criticism as a debate: objection, defence, residual difficulty.

HIGH

Verified PYQs and Applied Drills

Paper II
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

The following routes reproduce the verified demand of UPSC Philosophy Optional Paper II, Section B. Drills convert recurring formulations into practice prompts.

PYQ wording and marks are cross-checked against the local 2022-2025 question-paper PDFs and the verified _PYQ-PhilosophyOfReligion-2022-2025.md bank.

KEY DATA

Year / Marks	Verified PYQ Route	Core Demand
2022 / 10	Cognitivist and non-cognitivist approaches to 'God exists'.	Truth claim versus function.
2023 / 10	Wittgenstein on the non-cognitive nature of religious language.	Language-game and form of life.
2023 / 15	Symbolic religious language according to Tillich.	Participation, Being-itself and literalism.
2024 / 10	Explain the analogical nature of religious language.	Attribution and proportionality.
2024 / 20	Cognitivist/non-cognitivist accounts with Braithwaite.	Moral intention and realist objection.
2025 / 10	Is religious language symbolic? Give reasons.	Symbol theory and evaluation.
2025 / 15	Advaitic anirvacaniyata and religious language.	Ineffability, neti neti and levels.

STATIC THEORY

- **Applied drill 1:** Can analogy preserve truth without a literal core?
- **Applied drill 2:** Is Tillich's Being-itself a referent or a rule against idolatry?
- **Applied drill 3:** Does Braithwaite describe religion or revise it?
- **Applied drill 4:** Can Advaita consistently make claims about what is indescribable?

MEMORY HOOK

Read the directive first: discuss = balanced exposition; examine = test the claim; critically evaluate = objection, reply and judgement.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. Use the exact syllabus vocabulary in the introduction.
2. Distinguish exposition from evaluation with explicit transitions.
3. A statement question must first interpret the statement's philosophical assumption.
4. Never invent quotations; paraphrase unless wording is securely verified.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Listing thinkers without reconstructing their reasons.

CORRECT: Build at least one explicit premise-conclusion chain.

WRONG: Using Indian material as an ornamental final paragraph.

CORRECT: Integrate it where it changes the conceptual issue.

MAINS ANGLE

Begin with the two axes - how terms mean and whether utterances assert - before discussing thinkers.

STUDY LINK

Revise the PYQ rows alongside the doctrine and dialectic cards.

HIGH

10/15/20-Mark Answer Frameworks

Paper II
Philosophy

INTRO & ORIGIN

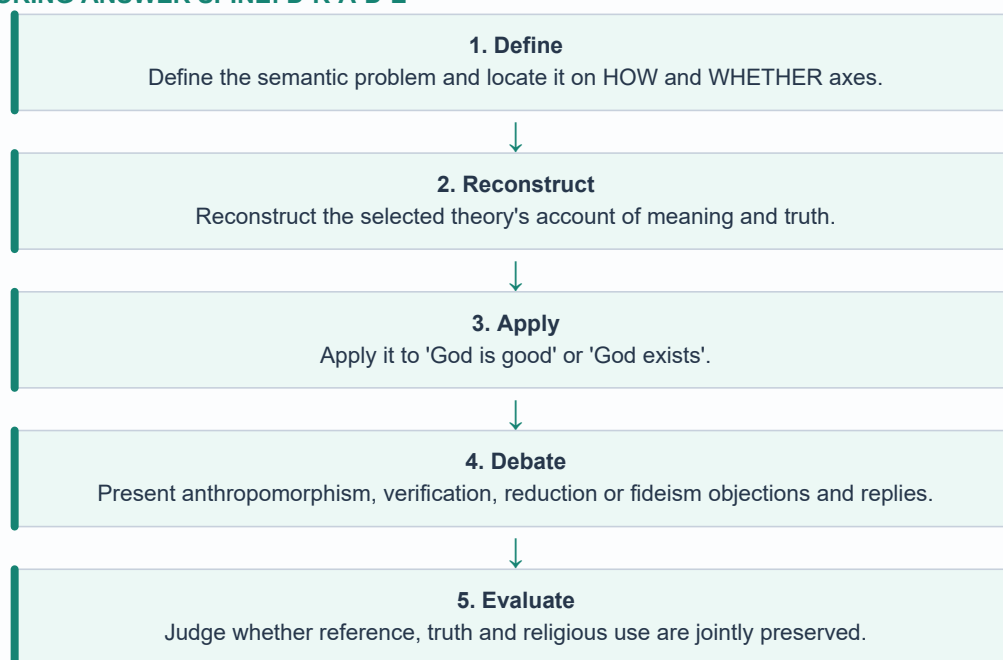
Answer length changes the depth of reconstruction and debate, not the accuracy of the doctrine. Every framework follows Define-Reconstruct-Apply-Debate-Evaluate.

These are answer architectures, not model answers to memorise verbatim.

KEY DATA

Marks	Recommended Architecture	Non-Negotiable
10	Define the theory; contrast its nearest rival; use one example sentence; add one weakness and judgement.	One precise distinction and one criticism.
15	Set the finite/infinite problem; reconstruct analogy/symbol/non-cognitive account; test reference and truth.	Internal logic, comparison and qualified judgement.
20	Build the HOW x WHETHER matrix; compare Aquinas, Tillich, Braithwaite, Wittgenstein and Advaita; defend a multi-function cognitivist synthesis.	Full dialectic, Indian-Western bridge and defended conclusion.

HIGH-SCORING ANSWER SPINE: D-R-A-D-E



STATIC THEORY

- **Aquinas line:** neither univocal nor equivocal, but proportionately true.
- **Tillich line:** symbol participates; literalism turns the symbol into an idol.
- **Advaita line:** provisional language guides beyond exhaustive predication.

MEMORY HOOK

Conclude: Religious language is meaningful when ____, truth-apt insofar as ____, and non-literal because ____.

MUST-KNOW FACTS

1. 10 marks: approximately 150 words; prioritise precision over range.
2. 15 marks: add one comparison and a developed objection-reply.
3. 20 marks: organise the answer around a philosophical problem, not a catalogue.
4. The conclusion must answer the exact necessity, possibility or truth claim asked.

UPSC TRAPS

WRONG: Giving the same compressed answer for every mark value.

CORRECT: Increase depth of reconstruction, criticism and synthesis with marks.

WRONG: Ending with 'both views are important'.

CORRECT: State what survives criticism and under what qualification.

MAINS ANGLE

Religious language is best treated as analogical or symbolic yet still cognitively answerable, while non-cognitive theories capture its lived force.

STUDY LINK

Final revision: master map -> argument -> comparison -> objection/reply -> PYQ answer spine.

End of Register Notes — UPSC Agent / Copilot CLI